

Indians as a replacement,” Nooshin explained.

Nandini’s WPL season illustrates the same principle, which Nooshin attributes to months of preparatory work. “She has spent a good four months in the CoE. She was even in the standbys for the India A team against Australia last year. And then she backed it up with the WPL performance.”

Her path underscores an important truth: WPL success does not automatically fast-track national selection. “She may get an opportunity, she may not. We still have a lot of fast bowlers (in the senior side). But she is in the reckoning, at least in the T20 format. And the bench has been built, which we were lacking earlier.”

For Nooshin, this is the real shift. “There is a roadmap which has been set. The player is not stagnant anymore. There is something they are always looking forward to. So the road is never closed.”

Built for readiness

India’s current depth in women’s cricket is the result of groundwork laid long before the WPL, accelerated by a defining moment — the 2017 World Cup. Biju George, part of India’s coaching staff then, remembers the profound impact it had.

“The moment that tournament ended, we were offered full-time contracts by the BCCI. That’s when things changed,” Biju recalled while speaking to *Sportstar*.

The BCCI moved from sporadic support to sustained investment, a transformation championed by former India captain Diana Edulji. What followed were structured programmes — Northeast camps, zonal camps and age-group initiatives — designed to cast a wider net and retain talent longer.

Biju had already seen the foundations of that blueprint taking shape earlier. He was involved in one of the first dedicated women’s Under-19 camps with full BCCI backing, held in Guntur in 2013-14, featuring several players who have gone on to become stars today.



Leading from the front: Captains Smriti Mandhana and Jemimah Rodrigues share a light moment after the WPL 2026 final. From a teenage talent who took part in early BCCI camps, Smriti’s journey to becoming a global icon reflects the impact of long-term investment in players. PTI

“The girls selected were around 15 and 16. Smriti Mandhana, Deepti Sharma, Meghna Singh and Sneha Deepthi — all of them were there. That was probably the first proper Under-19 camp,” he said.

Over a decade later, these pathways continue to churn out talents equipped to jump straight into intense match situations.

For this reason, Biju feels that A tours and even the Emerging Cups, though useful, often lack the right level of competition. “If India was allowed to field two teams, they would meet in the final. We are streets ahead,” he quipped.

If the pipeline builds readiness, it is the WPL that tests it like nothing domestic cricket can fully simulate.